

GPS Devices Tested

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We've only heard about GPS devices on the Internet and in the news, but we've never really looked at any products as such. People have little knowledge about GPS and how useful these units can be. It's assumed that the real use of GPS is only for those into aviation, marine and science related work. The other major misconception is that GPS equipment is extremely expensive, and to use it means that you require some sort of formal training or the other.

There are some other misconceptions that must be cleared before we proceed. You do not need GPRS to use a GPS unit nor is there a monthly or yearly fee to be paid to avail of GPS services. It's a one time fee covered when you purchase the device. GPS devices calculate and pinpoint your location using data from satellites and then put it on a map. Dedicated GPS devices come with maps and software preloaded on the device. Mobile phones that have GPS features don't come with such maps in most cases. These maps require loads of space and a good bit of processing power. Instead, those GPS software available for mobile phones download maps of the region you are in using GPRS. This is the only relation there is. All the products we've tested come with the software and maps inbuilt and require no external connections to download additional maps. We also reviewed some GPS receivers that connect to laptops and mobile phones, but they need separate software to operate.

We decided to see to see if we could get our hands on some GPS devices available in the market and we managed to get in products from MapmyIndia, Satguide and also some Garmin

Now, getting lost is also a thing of the past...

products from GPS India. This is the first time we've got in GPS devices and we decided to focus our attention on products that would best suit you, the end user. This category of products covers user friendly devices that anyone can use while travelling from one place to another. The whole point of using a GPS device is to make sure that you are never really lost – in fact once you use them, you know where you are at any given time of the day, anywhere in the world. Obviously this kind of information is much more important for specialised tasks. Fishermen, explorers and hikers will find GPS devices much more useful. Navigating through the urban landscape these days is no less of a challenge either.

What we looked for

This being one of the first tests of this kind for us, we looked mostly at the features in this mini-comparison of devices. Like any other human interfacing device, we looked for quality of the screens, the design for both the hardware and also the software interface. We look at how good the interface design was, and how simple it was to use. We tried adding a source and a destination point by searching through

the database and also using a direct pointing selection mode and looked at what kind of route the device would offer. Nobody wants a device that requires you to read a manual to tell you how to go from one point to another. We also looked for what kind of addons came along with the unit to attach to your car.

We looked at how easy it was enter in key points and routes. Some of the devices even came with a simulation mode which allows users to run through a demonstration of the entire route in advance. Some GPS devices even allow you to avoid certain roads while some others allow you to divert through another route. All the devices we reviewed ran on some kind of mobile software platform or the other. When you have some kind of processing power bundled with a touchscreen, there's bound to be some entertainment as well. So, we looked at some of the extra software features such as image viewing, movie and audio playback.

MapmyIndia A-MAX 06GP5A

One of the two MapmyIndia GPS devices received was the A-MAX 06GP5A. The device is



MapmyIndia A-MAX 06GP5A

meant to be used in a vehicle and comes with maps built into it. The device itself is compact and simple looking. The 3.5-inch screen on it isn't especially great but it gets the job done. Being designed for the car, the box pack comes with the necessary attachments to fit it on to the windshield of your car, for example. The touch interface is OK, and is not incredibly reactive. Scrolling around the map itself is a little difficult. The device has no buttons and is completely touch-operated.

The device makes use of a SD card slot to read maps. This is something seen across all the brands. The devices might be different but they all run the same kind of maps. The interface is slightly dull with a plain Windows XP-like theme running on it. The menu bars and the rest seem a little too thick and so occupy a lot of useful real estate on a screen this small. Charging is done through a mini-USB port and a separate 3.5 mm audio jack is also present if you want to hook up the unit to the car speakers or your pair of headphones.

The features on it are pretty impressive in general. The route and the maps on the device can be viewed in three different ways – the top-down view, the chase view and the last one which has both the views side by side. The maps are well detailed across the major cities and national highways are clearly mapped. This will be useful while you drive from one city to another.

The trip computer which represents a typical speedometer on a car is also present. Although not as fancy as some of the other models we've looked, the A-MAX 06GP5A shows your speed – the average as well as the maximum speed attained during your trip. A voice guidance system constantly announces and updates you of upcoming turns, and the distance to the turn. The voice quality is OK, but is loud enough for a car with the windows closed.

The GPS can be used for other tasks as well. The unit lets you play music, movies and even

view photos on it. In some ways, it's a bit of an entertainment system for passengers sitting in the front.

The speed of loading maps and zooming into them is a little slower than some

of the other GPS units. This also happens to be one of the models that MapmyIndia plans on phasing out very soon. If you're looking for a cheap GPS unit for your car, this is one to consider. It should be priced around Rs. 18,000. MapmyIndia is bringing newer models which offer Bluetooth functionality to connect to your phone, and should be out soon..

MapmyIndia 430 Classic Navigator

The MapmyIndia 430 Classic Navigator is one of the newer models to come into the market. Unlike the A-MAX 06GP5A, this one comes with a 4.3-inch screen which also supports a higher resolution of 480 x 270. The touchscreen is a little more reactive and the quality of the display is considerably better too. The hardware also comes with a newer version of the software than that on the A-MAX device.

The interface is one of the biggest improvements you'll notice in the 430 Classic. The theme used looks a bit like Windows Vista. The excessive animations are unnecessary, but the rest of the interface is made very professionally. The colours are bright, and give the device a very user-friendly look.

The volume control is placed on the side of the device. Like some of the other improvements over the other model, the 430



MapmyIndia 430 Classic Navigator

Classic too has a better speaker built into it. The On/Off button is a small switch placed at the bottom of the GPS.

The device also shows a graph of the speed and altitude over the trip. There are some features where you can choose road types that you want to avoid. The software automatically sets an alternate route. Like other GPS systems, you can look for hotels and other places of interest along the way. The manoeuvre route mode gives a list of turns along that route you've chosen. The device can also keep tracks of logs and journeys you've done which is useful for future reference.

The 430 Classic can also play media like the A-MAX 06GP5A. It supports AVI files, and the feature works rather well. The screen quality itself is average, so watching videos on them, although practical, isn't as much fun as a dedicated PMP. Image viewing also isn't great. This device is good for its performance, and the quality of speakers. It comes with a price tag of Rs 22,990 which might seem like lot money, but there's still decent value here.

GPS India Garmin Nuvi 350

Garmin is a well reputed name in the industry and the Nuvi 350 is first of the two devices from this brand that we reviewed. This is another dedicat-